Unit 6

Sixteenth Notes

New: Four sixteenths, an eighth and two sixteenths, the dotted eighth and sixteenth

A sixteenth note has two beams (or two flags) and lasts half an eighth: four of them fill one beat. Sixteenths come in a few common groups, and each group has its own look on the page. Learn to recognise the group as one picture and count it as one beat.

What is new

Four sixteenths

Four notes beamed together with two beams: one beat. Count 1-e-and-a, 2-e-and-a. In this unit four sixteenths always move by step, like a tiny scale.

Eighth and two sixteenths

One beam over the group and a second beam under the last two notes: long, short-short. Count 1, and-a.

Dotted eighth and sixteenth

A dotted eighth lasts three sixteenths, so the pair goes long-short, snappier than a dotted quarter and eighth. Count 1, a. It is the rhythm of marches.

Reading tips

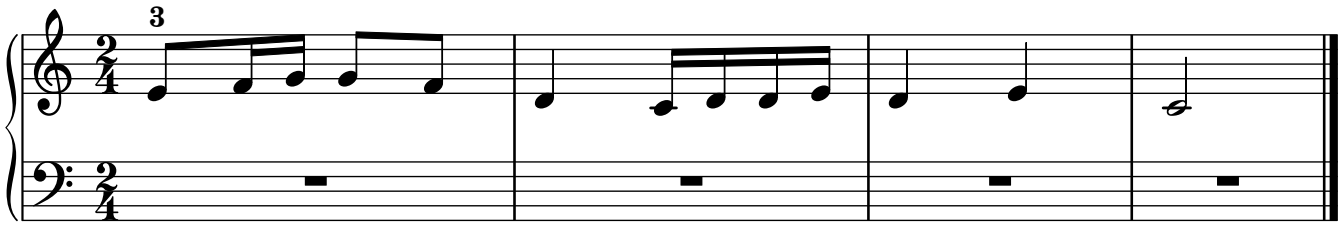
1. Count sixteenths slowly at first: say '1-e-and-a' for every beat, then just feel the beats.
2. Read four sixteenths as one shape: which way does the little scale go, up or down?
3. Keep dotted rhythms crisp: the sixteenth belongs to the next beat, almost like a grace note.

Part A: Sixteenths in the right hand

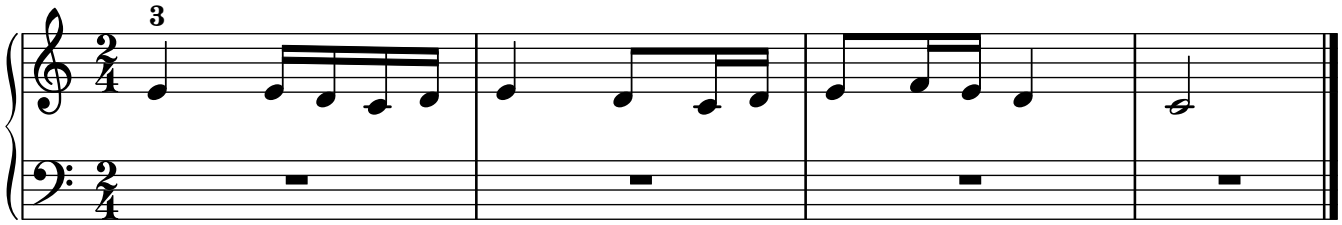
♩ = 60

Right hand in C position, 2/4: sixteenths in groups of four and two.

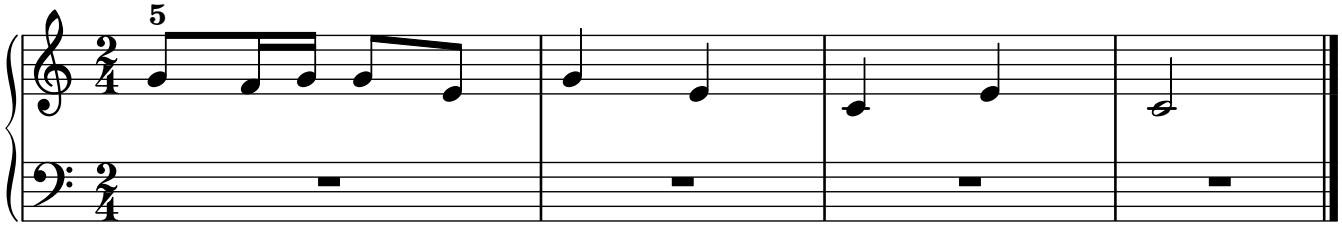
☐ **6.1**



☐ **6.2**



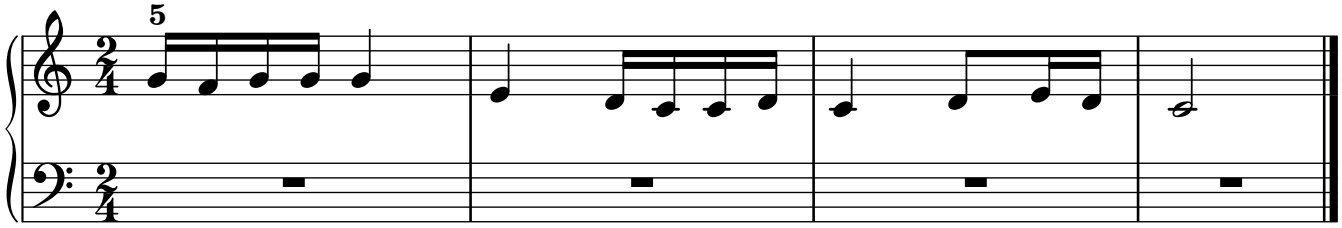
☐ **6.3**



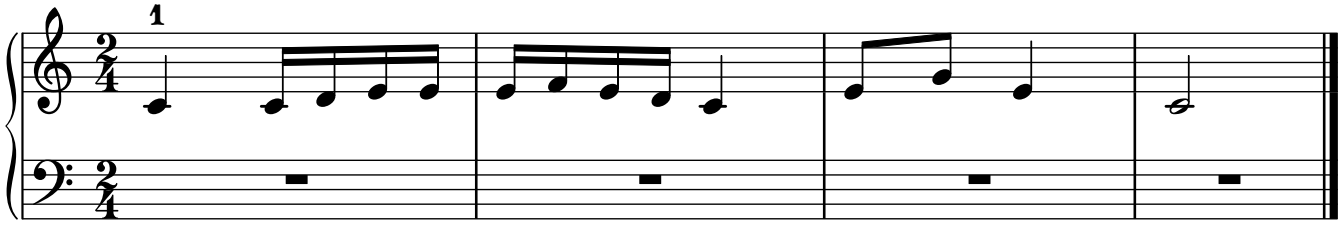
☐ **6.4**



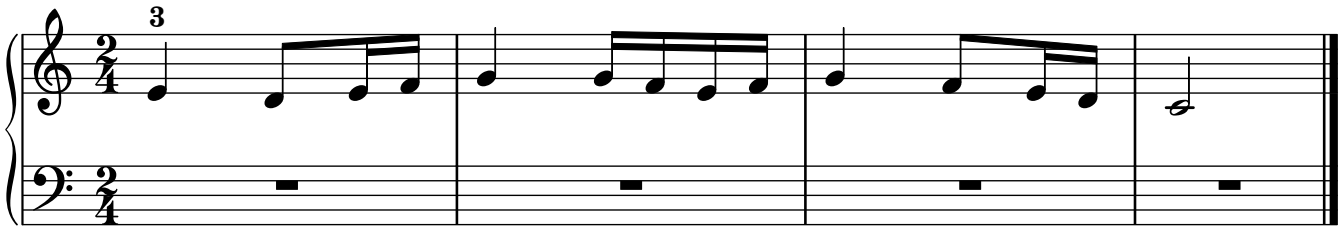
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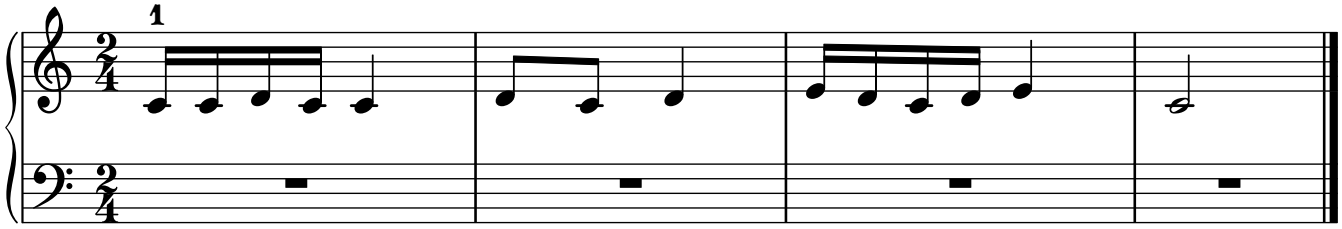
☐ **6.6**



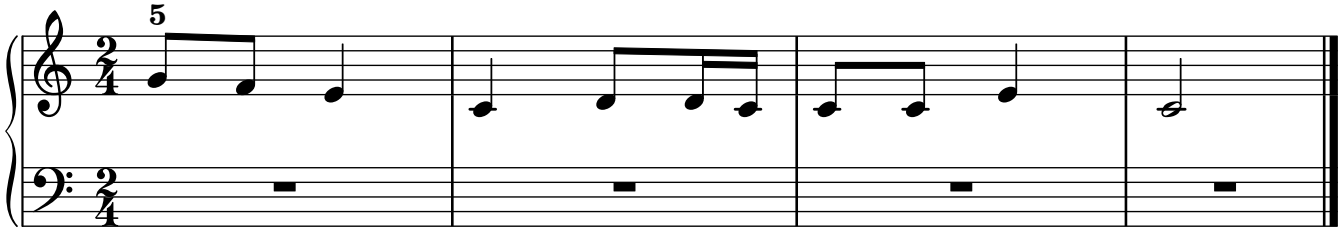
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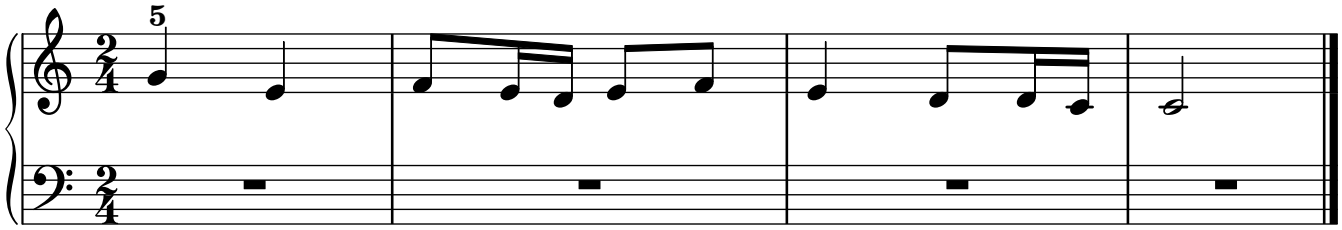
6.8



6.9



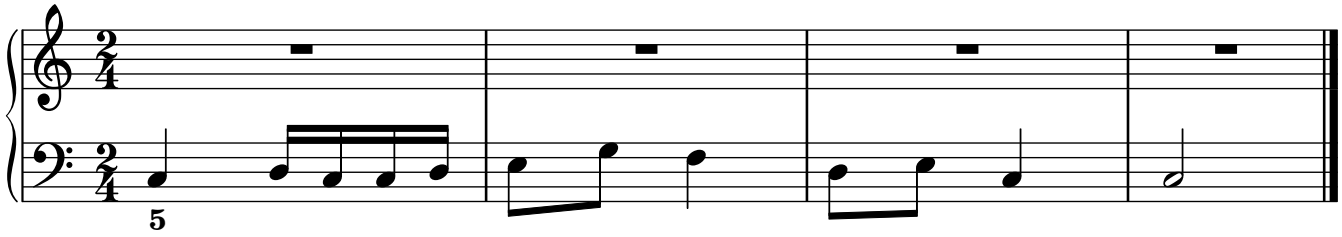
6.10



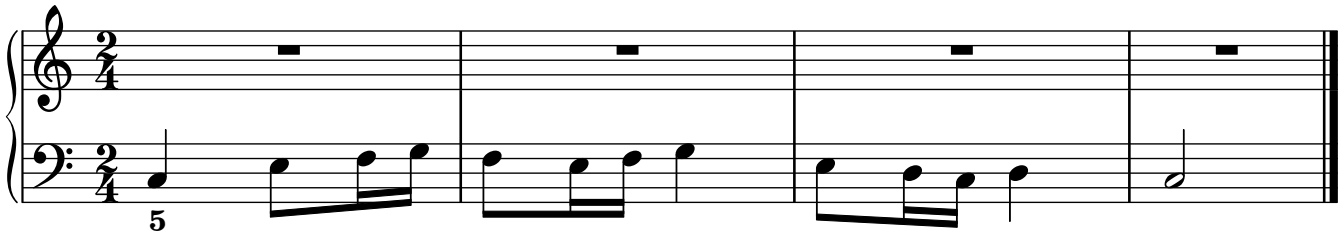
Part B: Sixteenths in the left hand ♩ = 60

Left hand in C position, 2/4.

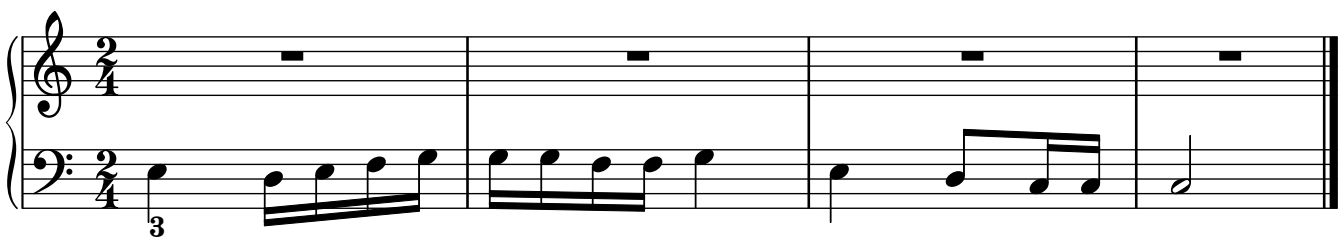
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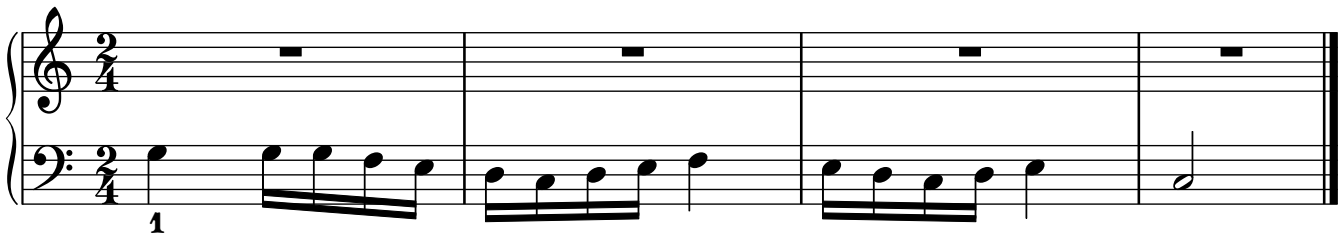
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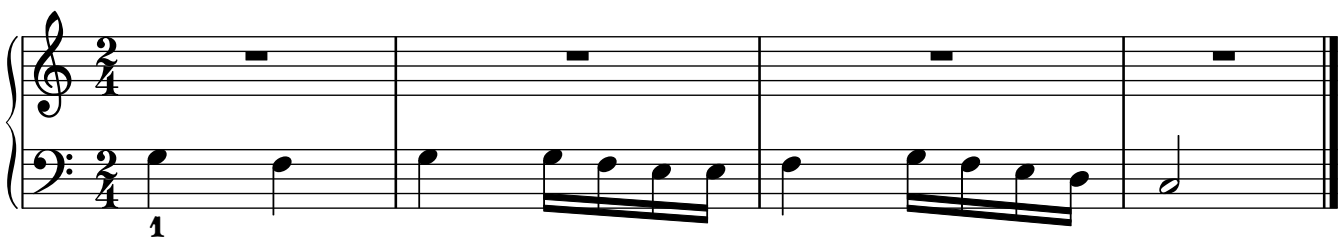
☐ **6.13**



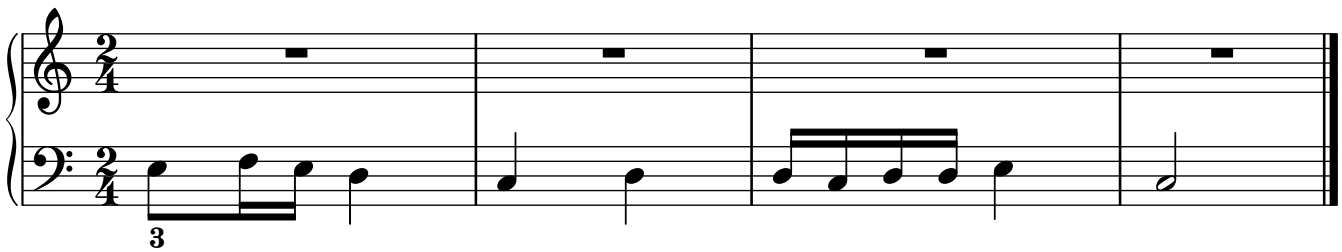
☐ **6.14**



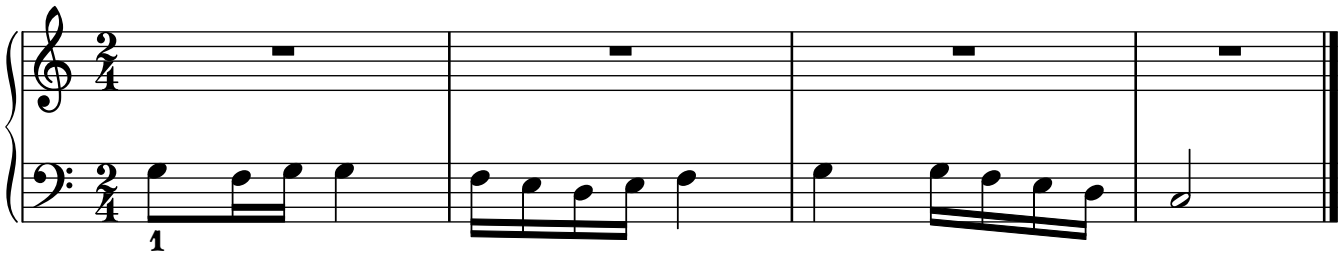
☐ **6.15**



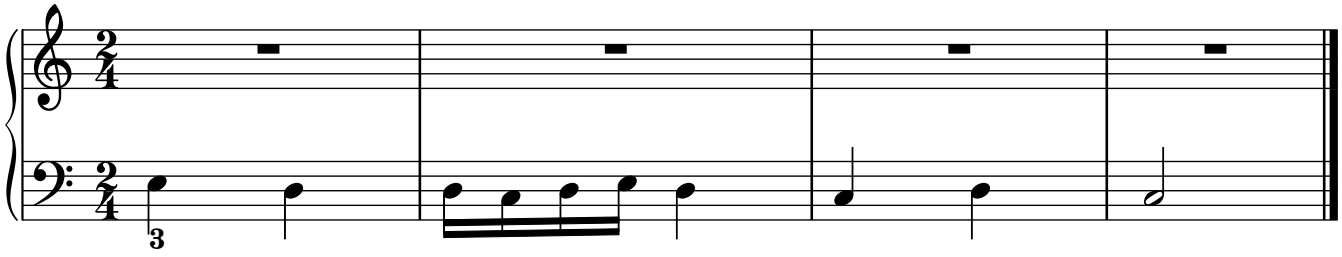
☐ **6.16**



6.17



6.18



Part C: Sixteenths over block chords

♩ = 60

G major in 4/4: sixteenths in the right hand over block chords.

☐ **6.19**



☐ **6.20**



☐ **6.21**



6.22



6.23



6.24



6.25



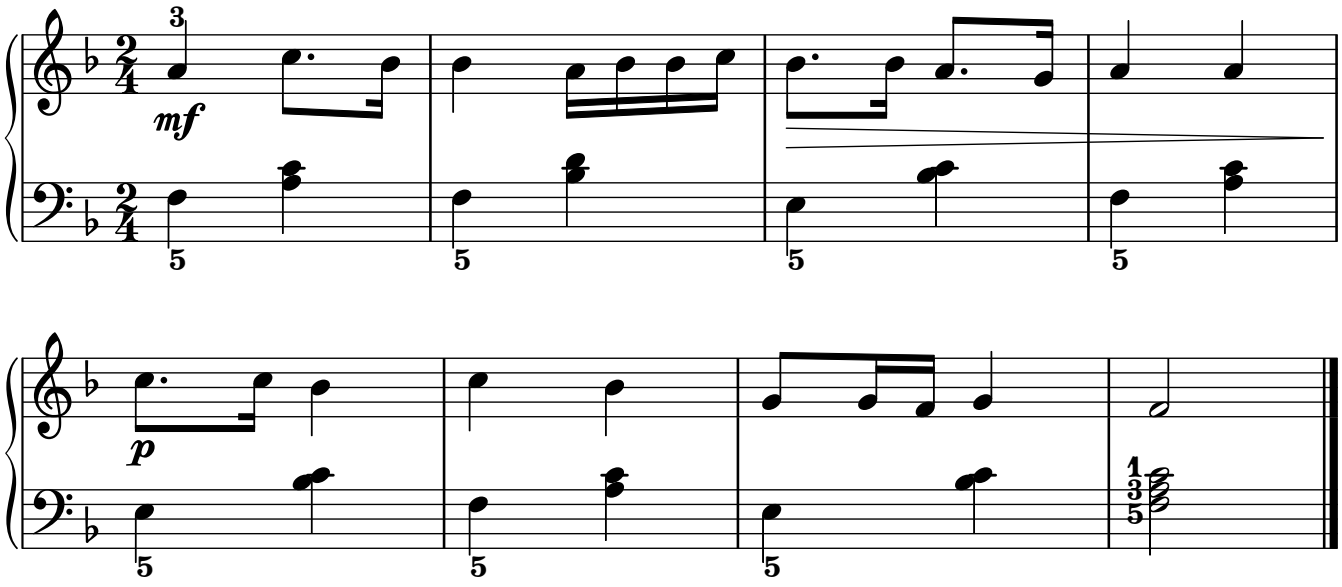
6.26



Part D: Dotted eighth and sixteenth ♩ = 66

F major in 2/4: dotted eighths and sixteenths over an oom-pah bass.

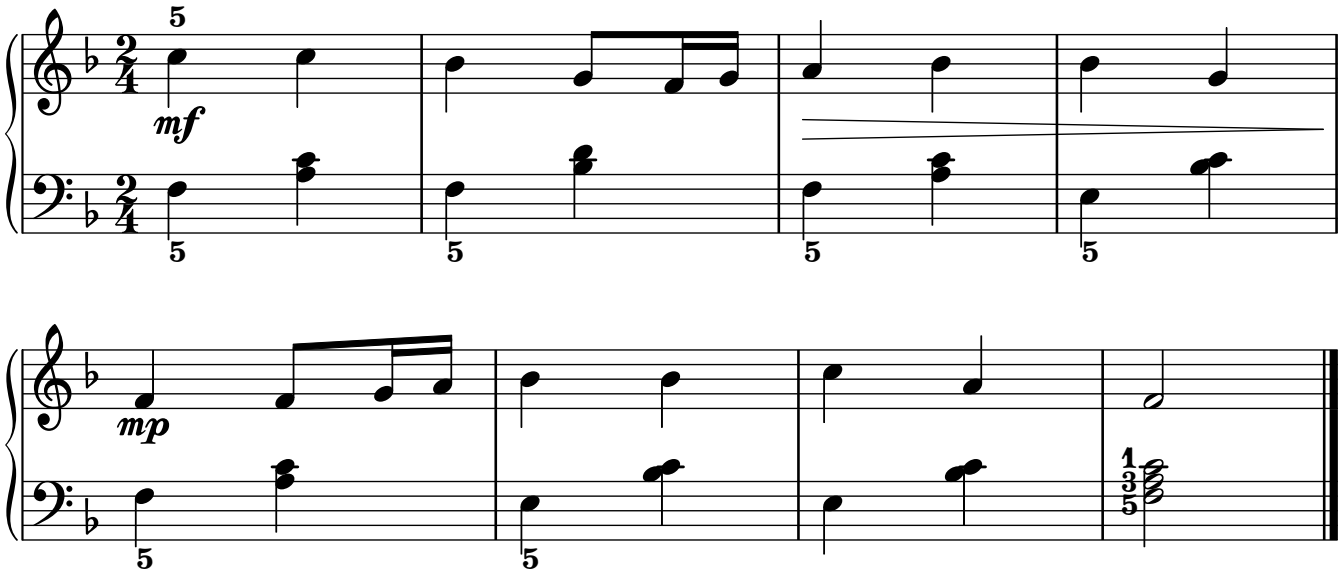
☐ **6.27**



☐ **6.28**



6.29



6.30



6.31



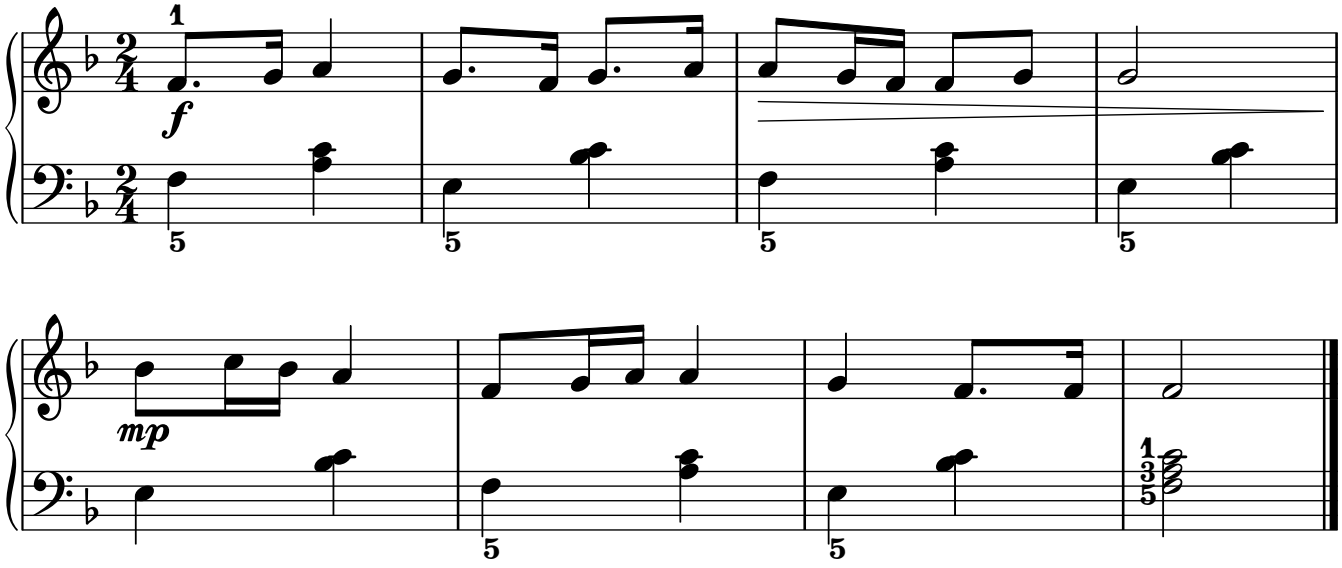
6.32



6.33



6.34



Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Musette in D ♩ = 72

From the Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach (1725), BWV Anh. 126 - first part

A musette imitates bagpipes: the left hand drones on low D in octaves, two ledger lines below the bass staff. The right hand starts high, on A above the staff, drops an octave in bar 3, and leaps back up for bar 5. Source: Mutopia Project no. 79.



Soldiers' March ♩ = 108

Robert Schumann, Op. 68 No. 2 (first part) - shortened

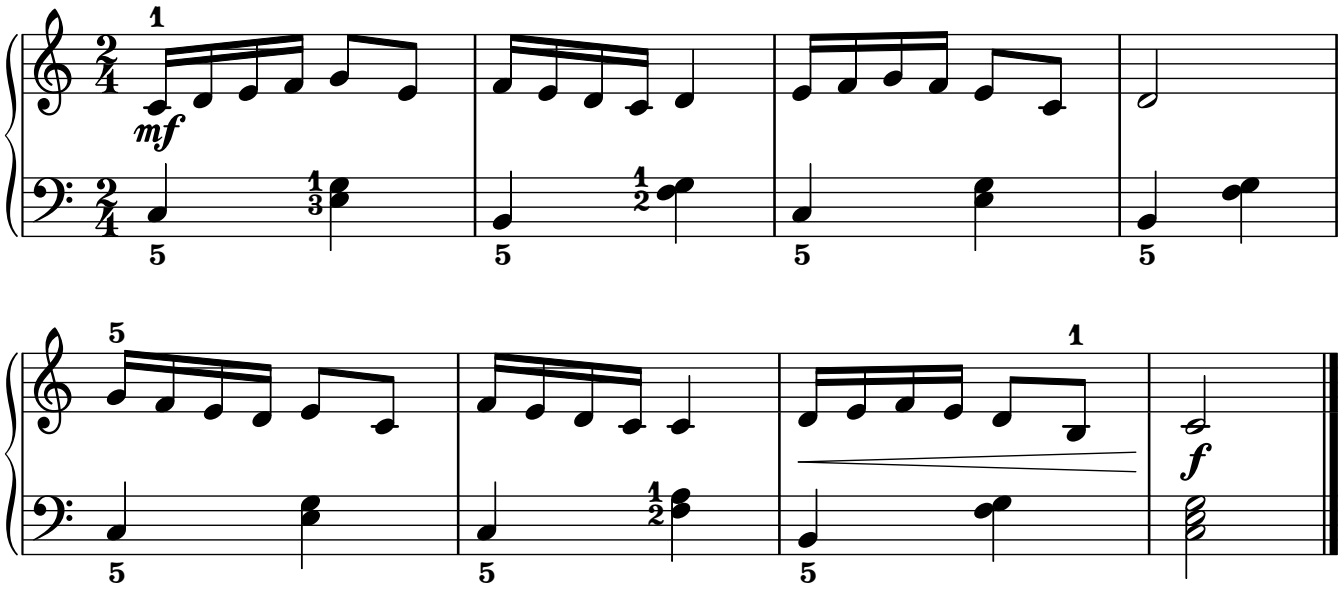
From Schumann's Album for the Young: crisp dotted rhythms and chords in both hands, with rests between the chords. Bars 1-6 are as Schumann wrote them; bars 7-8 come from the end of his second phrase, so the march stops at home. Notes from Mutopia Project no. 650.



Busy Bee ♩= 72

Original

Groups of four sixteenths buzz up and down the C position; each group is a little scale. The left hand plays oom-pah.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 7?

- Play five new Part B to D exercises at the speeds shown: at most one stop each, 9 notes out of 10 right.
- Every group of sixteenths fits evenly into its beat, and dotted rhythms stay crisp.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 7.